

Initiative / Self-Starting

Getting going without being prompted; investigating a problem independently and proposing a next step before stopping or waiting on someone else. This is often the hardest shift.

The student can...	Not Yet	Approaching	Proficient	Advanced
...start work without being prompted.	Sits idle after an assignment is given; waits to be told the specific next step before doing anything.	Gets started after a general nudge ("you should probably begin") but needs that nudge every session.	Opens the project and begins on their own, without a reminder, at the expected time or earlier.	Begins before the formal start, scopes what they don't know yet, and shares early drafts to surface issues fast.
...investigate a problem before asking for help.	Asks the first question that arises without attempting to find the answer independently.	Makes one attempt to find an answer, then asks immediately if it does not work.	Makes a genuine effort to investigate (tries a different approach, searches, re-reads) and then asks a specific, informed question.	Documents what was tried before asking, frames the question precisely, and proposes a hypothesis to test.
...propose a next step when stuck.	Reports being stuck and waits for the teacher to provide the next move.	Describes the problem but offers no idea for how to proceed.	Describes the problem and names at least one concrete thing to try next.	Generates multiple options, evaluates the trade-offs briefly, and acts on the most promising one.

Proficient = the competency is demonstrated reliably and independently (the target). Advanced = the student extends it unprompted.